

Assignment 2- Expository Writing

"Unboxing My Semester" Video – Assignment Guidelines

Assignment Overview

Create a 2-4 minute "unboxing" style video that reveals what you received from this semester, both tangible and intangible items. Like popular unboxing videos, you'll reveal items one by one, but instead of products, you'll showcase the skills, lessons, relationships, challenges, and growth you've experienced. This assignment combines creative video production with reflective writing to help you process your semester journey.

What You'll Create

Two Components Required:

1. **Completed Worksheet** (written component)
 - Brainstorming and item selection
 - Item profiles with descriptions
 - Reflective writing (3 paragraphs)
2. **Unboxing Video** (visual component)
 - 2-4 minutes in length
 - Shows and explains 5-7 semester "items"
 - Includes reflection segment
 - Submitted as video file

Learning Objectives

By completing this assignment, you will:

- **Practice descriptive writing** by clearly explaining concrete and abstract concepts
- **Develop reflective thinking** by analyzing your semester experiences and growth
- **Build multimodal communication skills** by combining written and visual storytelling
- **Demonstrate metacognitive awareness** by examining your own learning process
- **Create authentic, shareable content** that documents your academic journey

Part 1: The Worksheet (Written Component)

Section 1: Brainstorm Your "Box"

What to do:

- List as many semester "items" as possible (aim for 10-15+)
- Include both tangible items (physical objects, assignments, grades) and intangible items (skills, emotions, realizations, relationships)
- Don't filter yet—just brainstorm freely

Examples:

- **Tangible:** Annotated textbook, graded essay with feedback, coffee mug from all-nighters, notes from a breakthrough moment
 - **Intangible:** Confidence, time management skills, resilience, friendship, curiosity, independence
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Section 2: Selecting & Categorizing Your Items

What to do:

- Review your brainstorm and select **5-6 items** that best represent your semester
- Choose items that tell a complete story together
- Aim for variety (mix tangible/intangible, positive/challenging, expected/surprising)

Selection tips:

- ✓ Does this item represent significant growth or learning?
 - ✓ Does this item have a good story behind it?
 - ✓ Will this item be visually interesting or easy to represent on camera?
 - ✓ Does this item connect to other items in meaningful ways?
 - ✓ Does this item reveal something important about my semester?
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Section 3: Item Profiles

What to do: For each of your 5-7 selected items, answer four questions:

1. **What is it?** (Brief description—2-3 sentences)
2. **How/When I got it?** (Context—2-3 sentences)
3. **Why is it in the box?** (Significance—2-3 sentences)

4. **What does it reveal about your semester or your growth?** (Reflection—2-3 sentences)

Writing guidelines:

- Be specific and concrete in your descriptions
- Use sensory details when describing tangible items
- For intangible items, explain how they "show up" in your life
- Keep responses focused but detailed enough to be meaningful
- Write in complete sentences

Example:

ITEM 1: Resilience (intangible)

What is it?

Resilience is my ability to bounce back from setbacks and keep going even when things are difficult. It's the mental strength that helps me face challenges without giving up.

How/When I got it?

I developed resilience gradually throughout the semester, but especially after failing my first chemistry exam in October. Instead of dropping the class, I sought help and changed my approach.

Why is it in the box?

This item is in the box because it represents one of the most important things I gained this semester. It's something I didn't have at the start but built through experience and struggle.

What does it reveal about your semester or your growth?

This reveals that my semester wasn't easy, but I learned to handle difficulty differently. I grew from someone who avoided challenges to someone who can face them with confidence.

Section 4: Reflection & Synthesis

This is the **heart of your written assignment**. Write three thoughtful paragraphs:

A. The Big Picture (1 paragraph, 9-12 sentences)

Prompt: Looking at all your items together, what is the story they tell? What patterns or themes emerge? What does this collection reveal about your semester experience?

What to include:

- The overall narrative or theme connecting your items
- How items relate to each other

- The journey from beginning to end of semester
- Key turning points or transformative moments
- How you've changed as a student/person

Writing tips:

- Start with a clear topic sentence about the overall story
 - Use your items as evidence for the patterns you identify
 - Show connections between items
 - Be specific about what changed and how
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B. Most Valuable & Most Surprising (1 paragraph, 9-12 sentences)

Prompt: Which item is most valuable to you and why? Which item surprised you the most? What did you expect to arrive that didn't arrive, or what arrived that you did not expect?

What to include:

- Identification of your most valuable item with clear reasoning
- Discussion of surprises (positive or negative)
- Reflection on expectations vs. reality
- Your emotional response to unexpected items

Writing tips:

- Be honest about surprises and disappointments
 - Explain why certain items are valuable (now and/or in the future)
 - Consider what's missing from your box
 - Reflect on how surprises changed your perspective
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C. Looking Forward (1 paragraph, 9-12 sentences)

Prompt: Based on what you received this semester, what do you hope to find in your next semester's box? What items do you want to carry forward? What would you like to add?

What to include:

- Goals for next semester based on this semester's learning

- Items you want to keep/develop further
- New items you're hoping to "order"
- How this semester's items prepare you for what's next

Writing tips:

- Be specific about future goals
 - Connect future hopes to current experiences
 - Show how you'll build on what you've learned
 - End with forward-looking optimism or determination
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 Part 2: The Video (Visual Component)

Video Requirements

Length: 2-4 minutes (videos under 2 minutes or over 4 minutes will lose points)

Format: MP4, MOV, or AVI file

Quality Standards:

- ✓ Clear audio (viewers can understand what you're saying)
 - ✓ Adequate lighting (items and your face are visible)
 - ✓ Stable camera (not excessively shaky, use a tripod or prop)
 - ✓ Items shown clearly on camera
 - ✓ Appropriate background (clean, not distracting)
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Required Video Segments

Your video must include these four segments:

1. Opening/Introduction (20-30 seconds)

What to include:

- Brief greeting and introduction
- Explanation of the "unboxing" concept

- Show your "box" (can be literal or symbolic)
- Set the tone (excited, reflective, humorous, your choice)

Example opening: *"Hey everyone! So the semester is ending, and I thought, what if I could unbox everything I actually received these past few months? Not just grades or credits, but the real stuff the lessons, the struggles, the surprises. So I gathered everything into this box, and let's see what this semester actually delivered..."*

This is an example, you have to create openings that reflect the uniqueness that you bring in.

2. Item Reveals (2-2.5 minutes)

What to include:

- Reveal each of your 5-6 items one by one
- Show each item clearly to the camera
- Briefly explain what it is and why it's in your box
- Keep pacing engaging (don't spend too long on any single item here)

Tips:

- Use actual objects for tangible items
 - Get creative with representing intangible items (see "Visual Representation Ideas" below)
 - Vary your energy and tone to maintain interest
 - You can unwrap items, pull them from the box, or reveal them however feels natural
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3. Reflection Segment (1-1.5 minutes)

What to include:

- Step back from individual items
- Discuss the bigger picture (draw from your Section 3 writing)
- Share patterns, themes, or the overall story
- Reflect on what surprised you most or what's most valuable
- Don't read word-by-word from what you have written. Be conversational.
- Shift to a more thoughtful, slower-paced tone

Tips:

- This is where you show depth, slow down and be genuine
- You might sit down, change location, or shift your energy
- Reference your items as a collection, not individually
- This segment shows your critical thinking and self-awareness

4. Closing (20-30 seconds)

What to include:

- Final takeaway or insight
- Brief mention of what you're hoping for next semester
- Thank viewers and sign off

Example closing: *"So that's what this semester delivered. Some of it I ordered, some of it just showed up, but all of it taught me something. Next semester, I'm hoping to unbox even more confidence and maybe a little more balance. Thanks for watching my unboxing, hope yours was just as interesting!"*

Visual Representation Ideas for Intangible Items

Since many of your items will be intangible, here are creative ways to show them on camera:

Intangible Item	Visual Representation Ideas
Confidence	Before/after photos; standing posture comparison; video of you presenting
Time management	Planner, calendar, color-coded schedule, to-do lists
Resilience	Crumpled then smoothed paper; plant that survived; rubber band
Friendship	Group photos, screenshots of supportive texts, inside jokes written down
Critical thinking	Annotated articles, question marks, debate notes, mind map
Writing skills	Multiple drafts showing progression, tracked changes document
Stress management	Stress ball, meditation app screenshot, running shoes, journal

Intangible Item	Visual Representation Ideas
Independence	Keys, solo study space photo, decisions you made alone
Curiosity	Stack of books you read, list of questions you asked, research notes
Growth mindset	"Before" and "after" examples of your work

Be creative! The representation doesn't have to be literal; it just needs to make sense to viewers.

Video Style Options

Choose the style that feels most comfortable and authentic to you (you can choose something different too):

Option A: Traditional Unboxing

- Sit with an actual box
- Unwrap or pull out items one by one
- Casual, conversational tone
- Similar to product unboxing videos on YouTube

Option B: Cinematic/Produced

- More editing with transitions and effects
- Multiple camera angles
- Background music (keep volume low so narration is clear)
- Polished, professional aesthetic

Option C: Documentary Style

- Mix of you talking to camera and "B-roll" footage
- Show items in context (where you use them, etc.)
- Voiceover narration over visuals
- More storytelling-focused

Option D: Humorous/Creative

- Exaggerated reactions and commentary
- Parody of influencer culture
- Comedic elements

- Still includes genuine reflection

All styles are acceptable as long as you meet the content requirements and keep it academically appropriate.

Technical Tips

Filming:

- Film in landscape (horizontal) orientation or portrait (vertical), keeping in view what works best
- Test your audio before filming the whole video
- Film in a quiet location
- Use natural light when possible
- If using your phone, prop it up or use a tripod
- Film multiple takes if needed, you can choose the best one

Editing (Optional but Recommended):

- Free editing apps: iMovie (Mac/iOS), CapCut (mobile), Canva, Microsoft Clipchamp etc.
- Basic edits: trim awkward pauses, add simple transitions, adjust audio levels
- Keep it simple, content matters more than fancy effects